INDIA TODAY S2
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CHHATTISGARH FIRST

direct approach compared to other states. He said what he has done in Chhattisgarh is try to make development equitable. "Every citizen in Chhattisgarh has an equal right to resources. Labour and hard work are respected here and in the past five years, 40 lakh people of a population of 3 crore have shed the BPL [Below Poverty Line] status," he said. Baghel also laid out a report card of what his government has done to support farmers and improve the state's agricultural potential through the 'Narwa Garwa, Ghurwa, Badi' programme and paddy, sugarcane and millet procurement.

On the tribal welfare front, Baghel said his government has been procuring coarse grains at MSP (minimum support price) and has improved access to health services for tribal groups. The CM also said the enhanced interaction between the state government and tribals has led to a reduction in left-wing extremism. "During the previous government's term, the writ of the state extended to just 5 km from national highways.... Now, we have camps in hardcore Naxal areas like Minpa. The best thing I heard when I asked what had changed in the past few years was when someone in Sukma told me that people are now willing to marry their daughters there."

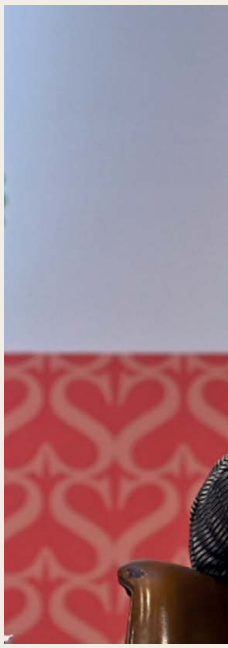


Deputy chief minister T.S. Singhdeo presented an honest account of his political journey, his views on women's quota and the Congress government's prospects in the state. It's a "clear positive for the Congress" in the next election, he said, adding that his party's welfare measures for farmers and women have held it in good stead.

The event also saw a dazzling performance by Padma Shri recipient Dr Bharti Bandhu and his group, who presented a stirring rendition of *Kabir Bhakti Sangeet*, while singer Amit Sana of *Indian Idol* fame spoke about his journey from Bhilai to Mumbai. Independent sessions were held on agriculture, business, women's empowerment, and youth. A resurgent Chhattisgarhi identity, as seen in the growing popularity of the state's cuisine, language and rural games, was a major talking point. As archaeologist and culture expert Rahul Singh put it pithily, "Our social identity inspires us to find more reasons for the world to say *Chhattisgarhia sable badhiya* (Chhattisgarhia is the best), instead of just us saying it to ourselves." ■

▼ THE CHHATTISGARH OF TOMORROW: POWERI

"No state in the country is giving what Chhattisgarh is giving to its farmers. No state is giving what it is giving as MSP for minor forest produce. We are ensuring returns for women's SHGs, promotion of English medium schools. The identity of Chhattisgarh has been brought to the fore and the government has been able to inculcate a sense of positive identity for the state. The focus has been taken away from Naxalism"



▼ THE AGRICULTURE PUSH: IS THE BAGHEL MOD



"Bhupesh Baghelji, me and others shaping agrarian policies have one thing in common: we're all from an agrarian background"

PRADEEP SHARMA,
Advisor on agriculture to Chhattisgarh CM

"Our first objective should be to be food-sufficient. Organic farming is essential, but we also have to keep in mind the cost"

KABIR CHANDRAKAR,
Progressive farmer, Chhattisgarh